



## THE WORST OF MAX VERSTAPPEN'S OLD HABITS CAME TO THE FORE WHEN BATTLING FOR THE LEAD WITH LANDO NORRIS

**Winning moment:** Mercedes' George Russell claimed his first win of the season at the Austrian GP. AFP

was here the Dutchman showed his craft when he took the lead from Russell on the third lap with an audacious move. At the same time, Norris got stuck behind Mercedes for most of the first stint, costing him valuable time. Verstappen quickly built more than a five-second gap, a lead that would prove handy towards the end.

Even as others pitted around him, Norris stayed out longer to have fresh tyres at the end of the race and, in clear air, set some impressive lap times. While Verstappen stopped for the first time on lap 17, Norris stayed out until lap 24 and made his last stop on lap 47, six laps after the Dutchman.

What was once a lead of more than six seconds gradually came down, and Norris came within two seconds of Verstappen at the flag. But the time he lost stuck behind Russell in the opening stint eventually cost him the race, and it was the second time in two weekends that McLaren let a win slip away despite having the fastest car.

### Friends turn foes?

While the on-track battle between Verstappen and Norris, who share a cordial friendship off the track, had been respectful, considering they weren't involved in a wheel-to-wheel battle, one always wondered what would happen if they came close on track.

Verstappen is known for being an uncompromising driver when fighting another car, and his early career showed that he could cross the line of what is acceptable in racing by deploying questionable manoeuvres.

The Dutchman had mellowed a bit recently, considering his significant car advantage and did not need to take any risks, even when fighting in a pack.

But all that bonhomie ended when the top two drivers in the standings clashed at Red Bull's home track during the Austrian GP.

The worst of Verstappen's old habits came to the fore when battling for the lead with Norris. After a slow pit stop reduced his healthy lead of seven seconds to three, Verstappen was being hunted by Norris towards the closing stage of the race.

Once the McLaren driver got

within DRS range of the Red Bull, an intense game of cat and mouse began. Having won the Sprint race on Saturday comfortably, Verstappen was now in danger of being humbled at the Red Bull Ring in front of his adoring fans.

At a time when Red Bull's advantage had shrunk drastically, red mist descended on the 26-year-old driver. In the past, he used to move under braking while trying to defend, prompting the FIA to clamp down on it a few years ago. Now, under pressure, those bad habits came back as he kept moving under braking, forcing Norris to complain about it.

Soon, he ran wide off the track to stay ahead when Norris tried to go down the inside. It was only a matter of time before Norris tried to make a move at the right-handed turn three, and Verstappen moved left to block the McLaren. Both drivers collided, suffering punctures and gifting Russell his second career victory.

Norris had to retire the car after sustaining significant damage while Verstappen limped back to the pits for a tyre change and came home fifth.

Though the Red Bull driver was handed a 10-second time penalty, it made no difference to his final position, and he came out of the weekend extending his lead in the championship but with his reputation tattered.

**Maximum impact:** When Norris (right) tried to make a move at turn three right-hander, Verstappen (left) moved left to block the McLaren, and both drivers collided. AFP

